1961: A Momentous Year

At a Warsaw Pact meeting on 28-29 March 1961, Ulbricht gave a blood-and-thunder speech, describing West Berlin as a sewer of ideological infection and political subversion. As the exodus of refugees from the GDR took a decisive turn for the worse, he presented a terrifying spur to action by claiming the Americans could use the city as a base for nuclear weapons and suggested West Berlin be blocked ‘with troops, barriers and perhaps with barbed wire fences’. Berlin, he said with a weary voice, was a ‘huge hole in the middle of our republic that costs us more than a billion marks a year’.

The situation, as some Warsaw Pact leaders recognised, was getting desperate. After some debate, Khrushchev gave the green light for Ulbricht to thrash out a ‘tentative programme of action’ for the division of Berlin, a task which landed on Honecker’s desk. (Officially, he was appointed ‘chief of staff’ for the campaign).

In the febrile atmosphere of the day, FRG media ramped-up commentary of the refugee problem. ‘If a million people, in peacetime, flee their native country like thieves in the night, leaving behind everything they own, the situation must be unbearable,’ FRG Federal Minister for All-German Affairs, Ernst Lemmer, told RIAS on 17 May. ‘There is a continuous and flagrant violation of human rights going on here.’1 Newspapers such as Bild detailed how 19,198 people fled the GDR in June alone; a good half of them under the age of 25. Responding, Honecker accused Western media of unleashing ‘nasty agitation’ against the GDR. He claimed ‘border violations and border provocations increased. Centres for poaching workers from the GDR had been set up in West Berlin’.2 Throwing aside all restraint, East German media intensified reports of ‘hostile acts’ against the GDR economy, all of which were blamed on Western agents or people ‘controlled’ from West Berlin. Ulbricht described the migration from the GDR to West Germany as ‘the trafficking in human beings, of the psychological warfare and sabotage directed against the GDR’.